

Concerning impact: Gokulam Kerala, a two-time I-League champion, is among the clubs that feel the MRA has contributed to the apathy of lower leagues. AIFF MEDIA

move to make the ISL the premier division. The Asian Football Confederation (AFC), in its roadmap with the AIFF, designated the ISL as the sole first division in 2019.

Promotion from the I-League to the ISL was introduced in 2023, with Punjab FC and Mohammedan SC earning ISL spots in the next two seasons. The uncertainty around promotion between 2019 and 2023 financially impacted I-League clubs

“That was the crux of the financial distress we had,” says Rohit Ramesh, owner of Chennai City, which won the league in 2019. “If you won the I-League, there was still no guarantee that you would play in the ISL. That was the beginning of the end.”

The new MRA draft from FSDL also shuts the door on I-League promotion for the next five years, ‘unless explicitly voted for by all stakeholders’.

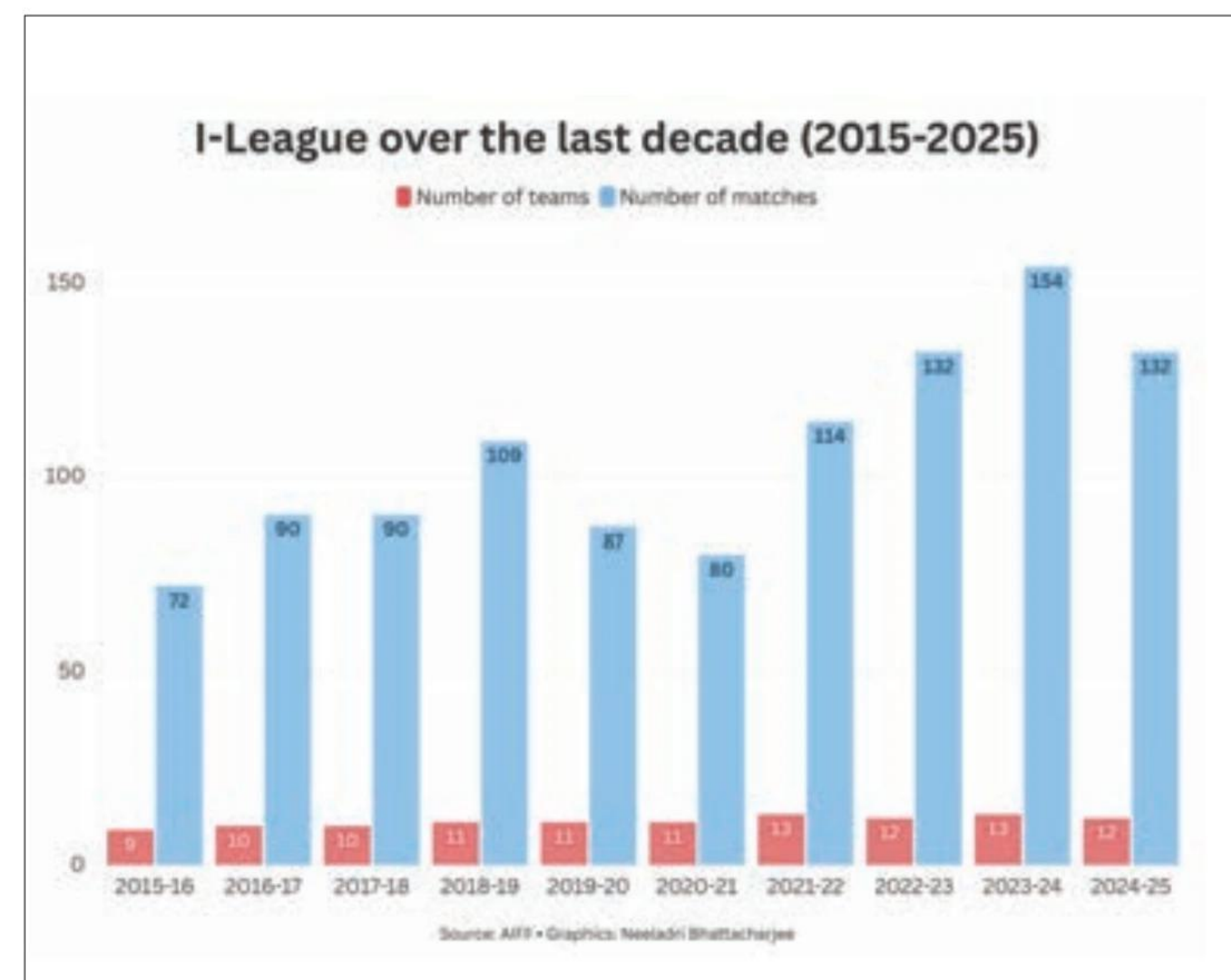
“What is wrong with promotion and relegation?” asks Praveen.

“Indian football is divided into rich and poor, and they don’t want the poor to come into the rich man’s league. Just because one club fails to meet the demand, they shouldn’t say promotion and relegation are difficult or uncomfortable.”

“Investors put money into clubs mostly because they see an opportunity to get into the ISL. That has helped the I-League to survive,” adds Anuj Gupta, co-founder of former I-League side Sudeva Delhi Football Club, which currently plays in I-League 2. If that stops, the league could shut down because there is no motivation.”

Financial struggles aplenty

The AIFF’s budget allocated for the I-League has kept falling over the years — from ₹15.1 crore in 2021 to ₹10.18 crore last year, marking a 33 per cent drop. Moreover, in 2022, the cost of



broadcasting was deducted from the clubs without informing them in advance.

“The production cost in the very first year (under President Kalyan Chaubey) was ₹2 crore. And that money — around ₹17 lakh per club — was taken from their subsidies without even asking them,” says Ranjit Bajaj, owner of I-League side Delhi FC, to *Sportstar*.

Clubs receive around ₹50-55 lakh in subsidies, and this deduction hit their finances significantly, by at

least 30 per cent.

Last season, with less than two weeks to go before kick-off, clubs managed to bring *Sony Sports* on board as the television broadcaster, paying ₹2 crore from their own pockets.

“Earlier, the I-League was telecast on *Star Sports*. Then they said no one was watching it — so how did we get *Sony*? So, the I-League club owners showed initiative and managed to get all matches broadcast on *Sony TV*,” says

